

tionally to support that message?

An interesting trend emerges here. Barring some large firms, for most firms in the Indian electronics industry, print media is still the most popular communication channel. Some of them, though, as highlighted by Ashok Kale, director, Sanstar India, are trying to opt for innovative cost-effective ways like technical blogs, web portals and CRM tools.

Though internal operational practices are often overlooked when creating an integrated marketing strategy, these are equally influential in building and sustaining your brand. A brand building exercise can never be successful without, for example, ample collaboration between business functions like marketing, supply chain, sales and production. Product quality, an essential part of a brand, is entirely in the hands of manufacturing. Another integral aspect of brand, namely, service, depends totally on functioning of the supply chain and sales and CRM. But it's not just production or client-facing functions that affect the brand. If your back-office operations fall short in processing orders, or are indifferent about defective products or services, the effect can be devastating to your brand.

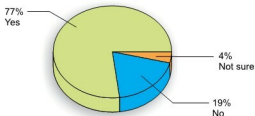
Differentiation or cost-leadership?

How to build or increase market share during a recession or an economic slowdown? It is difficult but not impossible. During a recession, every rupee matters to consumers and they use greater discretion in making purchase decisions. They prefer not to experiment with a new brand and tend to stick to brands they can trust. As a result, businesses often find it difficult to position their brands during a recession. But despite these difficulties, firms can gain success if they position their brands keeping in mind the product category and the expectations of their consumers.

Eighty-eight per cent of the EFY survey respondents believed that busi-

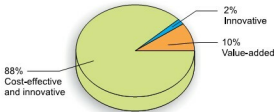
MARKET PRESENCE PROVIDES AN EXTRA EDGE

Outlook on the market presence during recession



COST LEADERSHIP AND DIFFERENTIATION HIGHLIGHTED

Brand projection outlook



nesses can succeed during a recession by projecting their brand from a 'value-added' perspective and also from an 'innovative-product' perspective.

There's not a one-size-fits-all answer. You must evaluate your company's brand equity in the market and the value of your products/services to determine the approach that is best for you. Try to know the concerns of your audience. Your audience may want assurances that your product/service will provide strong benefits and good value before they buy.

Focus on a niche audience. Figure out which segment of your target market needs you the most. These buyers will be more receptive to your message. The not-so-heard Indian brands, for example, often face problems in catching the niche market across the globe. Cermet Resistronics, though, has found an innovative way of doing this.

According to P. Hadilkar, director, Cermet Resistronics, "As an Indian company, it's difficult to sell products in the European market with our brand name. So we are planning to acquire

an European company and sell our products in Europe under the brand name of the acquired company."

Find ways to offer additional value, whether through add-ons or expanded services. This will not only help you with immediate sales but also help in the long run to retain consumers as your show of strength and flexibility during hard times instills a sense of trust and loyalty in your customers.

Bridge the communication gap. Though in a number of ways technology seem to have overshadowed the importance of the human touch in business, it

cannot replace the power of human connections. Leverage this idea and drop in to meet face-to-face with your customers and qualified leads. Ask them about their current obstacles and concerns and how you can help them. Listening intently and helping customers solve their issues goes a long way in maintaining momentum in the marketplace.

Call for proactive measures

Look at your product/service in a new way. Your offerings may have had a successful run in the past. In economic slumps, you cannot rely on a "same old, same old" attitude. Take a proactive approach and identify ways to leverage this as an opportunity for your brand. By doing so, your organisation will come out stronger, and quite possibly with a few new customers. "Products like People have personalities, and that can make and break them in the market place," once opined the father of advertisement, David Ogilvy. ●

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